also wrote that he was anxious that ‘the usurpers’ were using scholars and the ‘ulema to turn the people against him ‘and raise disturbances’.[41] He was right to be worried: his association with the hated Firangi infidels would remain his most vulnerable point. Religious xenophobia was always the most powerful weapon in the armoury of his Barakzai rivals.

Beyond the Bolan lay Quetta, then ‘only a miserable village of some 500 houses’. After that lay a second difficult pass, the Khojak, which was shorter and less steep than the Bolan, but even more arid. ‘They passed the night without water,’ remembered Mirza ‘Ata. ‘What water they could find was filthy and putrid with the bodies of dead animals that had fallen in, and any who drank of it immediately had stomach cramps and diarrhoea. They were suffering so much from lack of water that for two days humans and animals all were shaking like willows.’[42] Food had by this stage almost completely run out among the camp followers: some ‘were to be seen gouging carrion and picking grains of corn from the excrements of animals’, reported one officer. ‘I saw one day the body of a man who had died by the way side in the act of gnawing gristle from the carcass of a dead bullock.’[43] Before the army had fought a single Afghan it was already a wreck.

But there was relief ahead. On the far side of the Khojak, the invading army found itself in rolling pastureland where the scrub grass was dotted with clumps of dwarf oak and ilex. Occasional herds of fat-tailed sheep and shaggy brown goats belonging to Kuchi nomads were watched over by tall men in white turbans and purple robes, huge mastiffs at their heels. It was still arid and there was still a hot wind blowing, but wherever there was water a cool shade could be found behind the screens of poplar, some of which had vines entwined up their trunks.[r]

The army had now crossed an invisible border out of Baluch territory and into the lands of the Pashtuns. After the furtive Baluch brigands, Nott was impressed by the fearlessness of the Achakzai tribesmen, who strode proudly and proprietorially into the British camp and began interrogating their would-be colonisers. ‘They are very fine looking fellows indeed,’ wrote Nott to his daughters. ‘Quite the gentlemen.’ When one Afghan asked him why the British had come, Nott replied that Shah Shuja had returned to claim his rightful inheritance and that Dost Mohammad had no right to the throne. The Afghan retorted: ‘What right have you to Benares and Delhi? Why, the same right that our Dost Mahomed has to Kabul, and he will keep